



STATE AS THE CONGRESS FALLS PREY TO INFIGHTING AND JD(S) LIES HELPLESSLY DECIMATED

polls, when it emerged the single largest party with 79 seats.

The party's preparations had been well underway since last November, when B.S. Yeddyurappa was propped up as chief minister and then shamed after just seven days in power. By pulling the rug from under his feet, JD(s) honcho H.D. Deve Gowda and his son H.D. Kumaraswamy had provoked Yeddyurappa enough to launch a five-month, 9,000-mile *dharma yudha* across the state, where his plea was simple: "give me a mandate and I will give you governance and stability". For decades, the Congress had monopolised that alluring promise of stability, but this time, BJP wisely appropriated it. Plainly put, voters in Karnataka were fed up of coalition-induced political uncertainty, the machinations of the JD(s) parivar and the plain ineptitude of Congress leaders.

BJP had prepared its list of candidates a month before the Election Commission announced the polling schedule. It had the poll manifesto ready in advance and clearly projected Yeddyurappa as the chief ministerial candidate. In pitiful contrast, there was last-minute haggling for seats in the Congress, with a handful of former chief ministers contesting, each declaring himself the chief ministerial nominee and confusing the voters. Worse, senior Congress leaders were shamefully begging for tickets for their sons and relatives—a case in point being veteran C.K. Jaffer Sharief, who sulked after failing to procure a ticket for his grandson, with the party high command subsequently attempting to appease him.

If BJP already had a headstart, the gap widened as campaigning began in earnest. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh made a token appearance, Congress President Sonia Gandhi addressed a few meetings, while Rahul Gandhi's attempt to invoke the dynas-

SECOND COMING:
Yeddyurappa's tenure
this time will be less
fraught with uncertainty

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